CHAPTER

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Purpose in Life Under Adversity: Reflections on Purpose as a Buffer, Source, Constraint, and Target

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The scientific study of purpose in life under adversity begins with a clinician who learned the subject inside an Auschwitz barracks. “He who has a why to live for can bear with almost any how,” the line Frankl borrowed from Nietzsche within Man's Search for Meaning, was the field's first formulation of what later research would call the buffering effect of purpose (*Frankl, V. E. (1959). Man's Search for Meaning. Boston: Beacon Press.*, n.d.). Inmates who maintained an aim larger than the moment, Frankl observed, endured forms of cruelty that broke contemporaries of comparable physical condition but no committed aim. “Everything can be taken from a man but one thing: the last of the human freedoms — to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way” was the corollary, and it has influenced purpose research for more than six decades.

Developmental research has documented how purpose forms in adolescence and crystallizes into the aim that Frankl described (Baumsteiger et al., 2022; *Damon, W. (2008). The Path to Purpose: How Young People Find Their Calling in Life. New York, NY: Free Press.*, n.d.)(Damon et al., 2003). Studies of adolescents who experience marginalization have specified the conditions under which purpose forms despite, and sometimes because of, early adversity (Sumner et al., 2018). Longitudinal cohorts have shown that purpose predicts mortality across the adult lifespan (Alimujiang et al., 2019; Hill & Turiano, 2014)and reduced risk of Alzheimer's disease and cognitive impairment (Boyle et al., 2010), (Kim et al., 2025). Cross-construct work has tied purpose to multiple health and social outcomes across age groups (Bronk et al., 2009; Hill et al., 2018)(Cotton; Pfund &). Daily diary research has examined purpose in moment-to-moment experiences of well-being and stress, with the absence of a guiding aim identified as a risk factor for goal derailment (Hill et al., 2018; Ratner & Burrow, 2021)(). Across this six decade lineage, the question has largely remained the one Frankl posed. How does purpose protect a person when adversity occurs?

The buffer formulation is useful albeit incomplete. Frankl's own writings, and those of his contemporary Primo Levi, contain a second claim that the field has mostly ignored. Caring deeply about a mission, a commitment, or an attachment to something beyond oneself might soften adversity. The same caring also creates adversity. The inmate with strong attachments to family, profession, or political identity arrived at Auschwitz with more to lose than inmates without them. The pre-camp purpose, the same thing that fortified the bearer against suffering,

also made the suffering worse. Distance from the purposeful life he had bound himself disrupted the self. The deeply purposeful prisoner had farther to fall (*Levi, P. (1958). If This Is a Man (S. Woolf, Trans.). Orion Press. (Original Work Published 1947)*, n.d.), 1988).

A second omission is more recent. Adversity is sometimes aimed at a person's purpose. The authoritarian regime imprisons the dissident because the dissident has the purpose. The workplace retaliates against the whistleblower because a disclosure was made. The family ostracizes the convert because of a spiritual/religious conversion. In these cases, the buffer function fails to apply because what purpose offers is what obstacles, often in the form of people, try to dismantle. The literature on minority dissent, whistleblower retaliation, religious conversion under family hostility, and activist persecution has accumulated in fields that have not communicated with each other (*Hewstone, M., & Martin, R. (2010). Minority Influence and Innovation: Antecedents, Processes and Consequences. Hove, UK: Psychology Press.*, n.d.; Rehg et al., 2008)(e.g.,). The pattern these fields describe, adversity calibrated to the purpose, remains unmentioned in the purpose literature.

A third omission is that purposeful people facing ordinary adversity sometimes have *fewer* adaptive options than non-purposeful people in the same circumstances, because the alternatives have been actively foreclosed by the commitment. Consider the caregiver bound to a declining charge or the political activist participating inside their movement. These are the predictable downstream consequences of the same commitment function that makes purpose protective elsewhere. The field has been operating without a vocabulary for the pattern, with the result that interventions designed for the buffer pattern have been recommended to people experiencing alternative forms of suffering.

The Purpose of this Purpose Review

We argue that adversity is not a single entity. A precise account of purpose under adversity requires distinguishing different adversities and their causes, consequences, and trajectories. We identify four types. Purpose as buffer and purpose as source were present in Frankl's writing and have been elaborated empirically across the lineage just reviewed, though the source pattern has lacked sufficient terminology and detail. Purpose as target and purpose as constraint have been studied in fragments across adjacent fields. Neither has been integrated into the purpose literature, and neither has been distinguished from the buffer pattern.

This review pursues four contributions. First, we synthesize the existing purpose literature with attention to its strongest empirical anchors and under-named contributions. Second, we propose criteria for the kinds of adversity that purpose encounters. Third, for each of the four ways adversity links to purpose (buffer, source, constraint, target), we review evidence, specify mechanisms, and identify open questions. Fourth, we propose a research agenda based on the framework.

The review of these four types is developmental rather than definitive. The contribution is to extend Frankl's framing. We specify conditions when purpose is a protective factor, the conditions when it is costly, the conditions when it is attacked, and the conditions when constraints emerge.

A second part of the contribution is a recalibration. The empirical study of purpose under adversity began with one of the worst events in human history. The science of meaning grew up uploading lessons from Auschwitz back into ordinary life, and the field has often felt obliged to match the scale of the founding tragedy. Frankl was accurate about his observations and the buffer pattern he identified is the best studied of the four. The cost has been a literature that addresses extreme events more confidently than ordinary stressors faced in daily life. The framework offered here widens the lens. Purpose interacts with adversity at every magnitude, from the daily and the manageable to the medium and the chronic to the historic and the catastrophic. The buffer

evidence from Holocaust survival, combat exposure, and bereavement is necessary. That evidence should be tested against the full range of difficulties human lives produce.

Purpose in brief

The construct of purpose in life has accumulated a working definition across several research programs that have approached it from different angles. The most recent integrative effort identifies three defining properties on which the field has converged (Kashdan et al., 2024; McKnight & Kashdan, 2009a). A purpose is a central, self-organizing, life aim that is personally meaningful, oriented toward ends extending beyond the self's immediate interests, and stable enough to organize behavior across months or years rather than days. Similar criteria appear, with different vocabulary, in the literature on adolescents and young adults (*Damon, W. (2008). The Path to Purpose: How Young People Find Their Calling in Life. New York, NY: Free Press.*, n.d.)(Damon et al., 2003). The definition distinguishes purpose from four nearby constructs that the empirical literature has, often, conflated with it.

Some readers will notice that we refer to purpose as an aim, and aim is the term that motivation researchers usually reserve for goals. As such, it will be important to further distinguish these terms. A goal is something you can finish, like passing a licensing exam or running a half marathon. It has a finish line, and once you cross it the goal is spent. A reason is what sent you toward that finish line, and it remains after you arrive. Motivation researchers built this into a two-level hierarchy. Reasons and motives supply the energy behind behavior, and goals give that energy a direction (Elliot & Church, 1997). The two levels do different jobs. One reason can recruit many goals, and one goal can serve many reasons (Elliot, 2023). A woman who wants to ease the suffering of sick children might set herself the goal of finishing nursing school, then the goal of landing a pediatric position, then the goal of running a rural vaccination drive. Her reason holds steady while the goals are met and replaced. Another nurse could earn an identical degree for an unrelated reason such as a steady salary or a parent's expectation.

Inside this hierarchical framework, the word aim has been assigned to the lower level. A goal is defined as the concrete aim through which a person pursues a more abstract reason (Elliot & Thrash, 2001), or as a cognitive representation of a future object that a person is committed to approach or avoid (*Elliot, A. J., & Fryer, J. W. (2008). The Goal Construct in Psychology. In J. Y. Shah & W. L. Gardner (Eds.), Handbook of Motivation Science (Pp. 235–250). Guilford Press.*, n.d.). On that usage, aim and goal sit together at the bottom, capturing the specific, completable target.

We use the layperson's phrase reflecting a person's aim in life. Dictionary definitions fuse the reason for which something is done and the result a person intends, and that can be a source of confusion (Elliot & Thrash, 2001). Our purpose highlights the first meaning. It is the superordinate, self-defining orientation that organizes whole domains of goals, and it exists at the energizing, reason-giving level of the hierarchy, one tier above the goals it generates. This is why a purpose can be an aim without being an individual goal per se.

Our definition of purpose exists alongside the goal construct. A goal is bounded, instrumental, and replaceable. A goal can be set down when it stops working, replaced by a different goal, or abandoned at the perception that costs exceed benefits. Purpose is none of these things. A purpose is rarely completed. You do not check it off and move on. A purpose organizes the goals a person sets and outlasts the failure of any one of them. The nurse does not retire her purpose when a vaccination drive ends. She sets the next goal that serves it. Purpose works one level up, doing the organizing, while goals work below, doing the concrete labor. Abandoning a purpose is experienced not as a strategic substitution, but as a loss of self.

A *value* is evaluative and propositional. A value tells the person what matters but does not, on its own, organize behavior across time. Purpose links a value to action by committing the person to act on the value in a sustained way.

An obligation is externally imposed and persists through compliance. Obligations can become purposes if the person comes to identify with them. The conversion is precisely what distinguishes obligation from purpose. The conscripted soldier whose service the army imposes is not, by virtue of that service, purposeful. The soldier who has come to intrinsically identify with the unit's mission has a purpose.

A passing interest is short in horizon and limited in behavior. The person who enjoys an activity with regularity has an interest (e.g., (Silvia, 2001), 2006). The person who organizes their life around the cultivation of that activity over years has, potentially, a purpose. Most interests do not become purposes. The small fraction that do are recognizable by the durability and breadth of the behavioral shifting initiated to make space for them.

Two elements of the purpose construct are relevant to what follows in this review. Purpose is self-organizing. The person is the locus of the construct's repeated maintenance. External influences (parents, teachers, faith communities, sacred texts, cultural frames) can initiate the orientation, but the aim continues to hold only as long as the self, day after day, chooses to keep organizing time and attention around it (Baumsteiger et al., 2022; *Damon, W. (2008). The Path to Purpose: How Young People Find Their Calling in Life. New York, NY: Free Press.*, n.d.)(). Purpose is *stable* rather than fixed. It can evolve, renew, or give way to a different aim, but its operation over any given period is steady enough that behavior is organized rather than scattered.

Purpose often goes through a sequence of phases that have been implicit in the developmental literature: formation, maintenance, disruption, and renewal. Formation begins with a catalyst (a value confrontation, a transformative experience, an exposure to a role model or a need) and proceeds through a period of building commitment during which the aim is provisional (Baumsteiger et al., 2022)(Damon et al., 2003). Maintenance is the steady state during which behavior is organized around the aim and the formative inputs become less relevant. Disruption is what this review concerns. Adversity, situational change, or the person's own development can press the aim in ways the maintenance phase cannot absorb (Burrow et al., 2020; Ratner & Burrow, 2021)(). Renewal returns the person to a catalyst-like phase from inside an ongoing purpose, an option the field's accounts have left underspecified and which the adversity evidence will require us to develop.

The field's evidence base has been drawn predominantly from research on community samples assessed under ordinary conditions, with purpose treated as a variable that distinguishes individuals. The arguments that follow explore what changes when adversity becomes the focus as the situation affects a person's purpose.

How purpose is measured

A note on measurement is in order because the studies reviewed here used a variety of approaches. Most of the evidence relies on self-report. Some questionnaires isolate purpose as one dimensions of broader well-being, as in the purpose subscale of the psychological well-being scales (Ryff, 1989) and the abbreviated purpose indices applied to large epidemiological samples, where a seven-item index predicted lower mortality years later (Alimujiang et al., 2019). Others assess purpose directly as in the Purpose in Life test (Crumbaugh & Maholick, 1964), the Life Engagement Test (Scheier et al., 2006), and the Claremont Purpose Scale (Bronk et al., 2018). The instruments differ in whether they capture the presence of purpose, the search for it, or its content, and in how heavily they lean on a single global judgment.

A second approach uses semi-structured interviews. The Youth Purpose Interview asks people to describe what matters most to them, why it matters, and what they are doing about it, and trained coders then judge whether a person holds an aim that is both personally meaningful and acted upon (Damon, Menon, & Bronk, 2003). This method separates respondents that questionnaire scores blur together, distinguishing people who have committed to a life aim from those who only aspire to one and those who drift without a discernable purpose.

A third approach measures purpose as something enacted day to day. In our own work, for example, we asked people to list their current strivings with the stem "I am trying to," then to mark with an asterisk the one striving that best captured the central, self-organizing aim of their life (Kashdan & McKnight, 2013). Participants carried that aim on a card in their wallet as a physical reminder. Across the following weeks, they reported each day how much effort they devoted to that purpose and how much progress they made toward it. This locates purpose initially in what they say about themselves through self-reflection followed by what people do in their natural environments.

In a fourth approach, researchers manipulated purpose directly, usually by having participants write for a few minutes about their aims. These inductions influence outcomes ranging from passenger mood on racially mixed commuter trains (Burrow & Hill, 2013), preferences between more and less diverse cities shown on demographic maps (Burrow et al., 2014), the perceived steepness of a hill relative to the effort of climbing it (Burrow et al., 2016), and split-second decisions to shoot armed and unarmed targets in police simulations (Burd et al., 2024). Writing inductions often allow for adequate tests of causality and they show that purpose changes self-descriptions, perceptions, and most importantly, approach-oriented behavior.

Readers should hold this variation in mind when results from different programs are compared. Some of the apparent inconsistency across studies reflects heterogeneity in measurement rather than in the construct.

Criteria Relevant to Thinking About Adversity

The features proposed here distinguish adversities along dimensions to which purpose responds differently. At least five features matter.

Timescale

Acute adversities are bounded events that a person must absorb within a defined window, such as a car accident, a sudden loss, an assault, or job loss. Chronic adversities are sustained pressures the person must operate within indefinitely, such as long-duration caregiving, systemic discrimination, chronic illness, or occupational injustice. The distinction is empirically validated. The modal trajectory after acute trauma is resilience, with chronic distress reported in a minority of exposed individuals (Bonanno, 2004). The modal trajectory under chronic strain is different in shape and slower to recover, with cumulative effects on physical and mental health that acute-event research did not predict and is not designed to detect.

Controllability

Adversities within the person's control (a chosen sacrifice, a difficult conversation, a self-imposed challenge) interact with purpose differently than adversities outside the person's control (an unexpected diagnosis, a natural disaster, a coup). The literature has often merged these, with the result that estimates of purpose buffering effects mix two phenomena that the framework predicts should operate differently. Controllable adversity may activate the narrowing of attention and energy adaptively, whereas uncontrollable adversity may exhaust the same function.

Proximity to the purpose's content

Some adversities are irrelevant to purpose, such as a flu, a flat tire, or a difficult interaction with a stranger. Purpose is engaged only insofar as the adversity disrupts the everyday platform from which purposeful action proceeds. Other adversities bear directly on the conditions the purpose requires. A purpose to be a parent is engaged differently by a child's illness than by a personal flu. Adversities that target the purpose are the limiting case, where the adversity is aimed at the purpose itself.

Institutional involvement

Individual adversities (the diagnosis, the accident, the personal loss) interact with the person alone. Systemic adversities (racism, poverty, authoritarian persecution, structural occupational exclusion) interact with the person through the social and political environment as well. Systemic adversities are chronic by definition, and their interaction with purpose is consequential. A purpose to challenge systemic adversity converts the situation from the constraint pattern to the target pattern, with all the implications for outcome the target evidence will show.

Developmental phase at onset

Adversity during purpose formation (childhood, adolescence) produces different trajectories than adversity during established maintenance phases. The developmental literature on adversity-exposed youth has documented this pattern in detail. Early-life adversity can foreclose purpose formation, redirect it toward survival-organized aims, or accelerate it into purposes that would otherwise have emerged later. Phase at onset is relevant because the four types do not operate identically across phases. A person whose purpose is in formation when adversity strikes is more likely to enter the source type. A person whose purpose is in established maintenance is more likely to enter the buffer or constraint type.

The criteria matter because purpose responds differently to different classes of adversity. A study that pools acute and chronic adversity, controllable and uncontrollable cases, and adversities at different distances from the purpose itself will produce estimates that average over heterogeneous mechanisms and obscure meaningful psychological differences. This is not a methodological complaint about specific studies. It is a claim about why progress on the adversity side of purpose science has been slower than progress on ordinary existence.

Open questions for the criteria

Are the five features independent, or do they cluster into a smaller number of latent adversity types that are functionally equivalent on purpose? Is there a class of adversity irrelevant to purpose that nonetheless depletes a person's resources and thus, interferes with purpose (e.g., a flu cascade that compounds into social role failure)?

Purpose as Buffer

The buffering literature is the largest and most internally consistent of the four types. Purposeful individuals show better health outcomes than less purposeful individuals across a range of stress exposures, with effect sizes that survive controls for related constructs and have been replicated across cohorts. The interesting questions are whether the buffer exists and, even more so, which components of purpose do the buffering work, what the buffer's boundary conditions are, and when the buffer fails.

Strong evidence comes from a large prospective cohort of US adults older than 50 years (N = 6,985 in the Health and Retirement Study), in which life purpose scores measured at baseline predicted all-cause mortality across four years of follow-up after statistically adjusting for demographic, behavioral, and clinical variables (Alimujiang et al., 2019). The pattern is dose responsive whereby each one-unit increase on the seven-item purpose measure was associated with reduced mortality risk, and the lowest purpose category had mortality risk more than double the

highest. A separate longitudinal analysis using the Midlife in the United States cohort found that purpose predicted mortality across adult years independently of other psychological well-being indicators, and the longevity effect did not depend on participants' age, follow-up duration, or retirement status (Hill & Turiano, 2014). This pattern of results is not specific to mortality. In community-dwelling older adults followed for up to seven years, baseline purpose halved the risk of incident Alzheimer's disease and reduced the rate of mild cognitive impairment, with the effect remaining after adjusting for cognitive function, depressive symptoms, and personality dimensions (Boyle et al., 2010).

Purpose is not a behavior, and it cannot directly affect cellular pathology. What it does is organize behavior over long stretches of time in ways that aggregate into a protective factor. Purposeful individuals report sleep that is more regular, dietary patterns that are more disciplined, smoking and substance use that is lower, and healthcare use that is more proactive. These behavioral mediators account for some of the buffering effect, but unexplained variance remains. Even after accounting for alternative explanations, residual effects can be found for biomarkers and mortality, suggesting that purpose buffers through additional pathways that the behavioral mediator literature has not yet detected.

The psychological pathway includes meaning-making. Stressful events without an interpretive framework produce more cognitive intrusion, more rumination, and slower resolution than events embedded in a framework that locates them in a longer arc (Park, 2010). The framework purpose provides is future oriented, organizing the present loss against a long-term trajectory. A bereaved parent whose purpose is to advocate for other families relocates the loss in a meaning structure that the loss alone does not generate, and this downstream benefit does not require the parent to feel better about the loss.

The protective effect of purpose on well-being is multifaceted, operating across domains that range from physical health to social engagement to subjective well-being, with effect sizes varying systematically by domain rather than appearing uniformly across them (Pfund & (Hill et al., 2018). Purpose also predicts increased healthcare use and reduced hospitalization rates in older adults, an effect that operates partly through proactive health behavior and partly through the framing of symptoms as instances to manage (Schaefer et al., 2013). The cross-cultural literature has begun to test whether the buffering effect generalizes, and the available evidence suggests it does, with culture moderating the content of purposes more than the magnitude of effects.

A meta-analysis across 16 samples confirmed that purpose is reliably associated with lower subjective stress, with the association holding across age, sex, race, education, and prior psychological distress. The negative association appeared in 13 of the 16 samples (Sutin et al., 2024). The buffering effect is not confined to majority populations or ordinary stressors. Purpose moderates the relationship between perceived discrimination and cognitive functioning in midlife and older adults, such that high-purpose individuals show less cognitive decrement at any given level of reported discrimination (Farmer et al., 2025). Purpose moderates the relationship between depressive symptoms and memory over a 12-year follow-up in 4,599 older adults, with the negative association between depression and memory weaker for individuals with stronger purpose (Lewis & Hill, 2021). Purpose also buffers the link between depressive symptoms and loneliness on the one hand and subjective cognitive decline on the other (Pfund et al., 2022). Devoting effort toward, or making progress toward, a purpose on a given day buffers the daily impact of social anxiety disorder on negative emotions, positive emotions, self-esteem, and meaning-making (Kashdan & McKnight, 2013). The pattern across these moderation studies is

consistent. Purpose attenuates the psychological cost path through which adversity translates into cognitive, emotional, and functional decline.

When the buffer fails

Adversity that specifically targets the purpose (detailed below) bypasses the buffer entirely, because the buffer cannot operate on a force aimed at dismantling it. Adversity that exhausts the resources purpose runs on, such as sustained sleep disruption, prolonged caregiver strain, or chronic resource scarcity, erodes the behavioral and attentional substrate required for a buffering effect. The same purpose that buffered earlier becomes inert under sustained depletion. Adversity during purpose formation is less easily buffered because the protective mechanisms have yet to be consolidated.

Open questions for the buffer pattern

Is the buffering effect mediated primarily by narrative interpretation, by behavioral activity, or a pathway the field has not yet identified, and does the answer differ by adversity type? Can the buffer be experimentally produced in non-purposeful adults under acute laboratory stress, and if so, what dose of induced purpose is required? Does the buffer have a refractory period? That is, does sustained operation deplete the resource the buffer draws on, with the prediction that the same purpose protects less in year ten than in year one of a chronic exposure? Is there a class of adversity for which the buffer is counterproductive, in the sense that the cognitive narrowing the buffer requires prevents adaptive responses that a non-purposeful person would make available?

Purpose as Source

Some purposes form in response to adversity (Kashdan & McKnight, 2009). The trauma survivor becomes a protector. The bereaved becomes an advocate. The patient becomes a clinician. Where the buffer pattern shows purpose softening adversity, the source pattern shows adversity producing purpose. The pattern has been most extensively studied under the heading of post-traumatic growth, and the literature in that area provides evidence and empirical complications.

The foundational claim of the post-traumatic growth literature is that some individuals report positive psychological changes following traumatic events, including increased appreciation of life, deeper relationships, renewed sense of personal strength, recognition of new possibilities, and spiritual development (Tedeschi & Calhoun, 2004). The reported changes are common enough to be statistically reliable across studies and have been measured by psychometrically sound inventories. The growth construct has organized research across bereavement, illness, combat exposure, sexual assault, and natural disaster, and it has supported intervention designs aimed at facilitating positive meaning-making in clinical populations.

A few unusual findings appear in longitudinal studies. In a study comparing self-reported post-traumatic growth to *actual* changes in growth-related domains measured before and after the traumatic event, the two measures were essentially uncorrelated (Frazier et al., 2009). Self-reported growth was associated with increased distress from pre- to post-trauma, whereas actual growth was associated with decreased distress. The two measures, in other words, were tracking different phenomena. Self-reported growth appears to be partly an interpretive frame survivors construct retrospectively, a meaning-making act that helps the survivor narrate the event in a tolerable way. Actual growth is something the field has been mostly inferring from the report rather than measuring directly.

The post-traumatic growth literature has integrated this critique by treating growth as a personality-change phenomenon that requires longitudinal verification rather than retrospective self-report (Jayawickreme & Blackie, 2014). Actual growth is detectable in personality and behavioral measures across the trauma window, and the growth that meets this criterion is

correlated with the kind of adaptive functioning that retrospective growth reports do not consistently predict. The source pattern of purpose is the personality change version, where adversity produces an aim sustained over years and observable in consistent behavior over a long period.

The largest cross-national test of adversity's long-term effects on purpose comes from the Global Flourishing Study (N = 202,898 across 22 countries), which examined the childhood correlates of adult purpose and meaning. Childhood economic hardship, parental loss, abuse, alienation, and poor health predicted *lower* adult purpose. Good relationships with parents, economic stability, and good health predicted *higher* purpose (Kim et al., 2025). The data complicates any simple reading of the source pattern as a simple equation where suffering turns into an aim. Adversity sometimes catalyzes purpose and sometimes depletes it, and the contingencies are what must be explored. A complementary analysis of adverse childhood experiences and adult meaning found that ACEs predicted lower coherence and lower significance but, controlling for those, were *unrelated* to purpose (Rose et al., 2023). Purpose may be the meaning dimensions that is the strongest predictor of motivational strength emerging from early adversity, even when other meaning dimensions are compromised (i.e., significance, coherence). A second strand of evidence that bridges to the buffer pattern shows that meaning in life is reliably associated with positive coping with everyday stressors (proactive planning, coping self-efficacy, positive reinterpretation) across recalled, anticipated, and experienced stressful events in five studies (Ward et al., 2023). The everyday stressor evidence is useful for this review because it counters the field's historical anchoring to extreme events.

The source pattern does not require adversity to produce a purpose that increases the bearer's well-being. Activist purpose, taken as a case in point, correlates simultaneously with indicators of well-being *and* with indicators of psychological concern (Wolk et al., 2024). Commitments catalyzed by adversity come with costs the literature has rarely acknowledged, and the dual association in the activist data is clear evidence that the source pattern is not a benign conversion of pain into meaning. The framework offered here treats this dual association as a defining feature of the source pattern.

Durable versus brittle purposes catalyzed by adversity

The literature on bereaved adults who organize their lives around the cause of the loss has identified predictors of durability. Breadth of the aim is relevant. A purpose to prevent the cause of the specific loss tends to be more brittle than a purpose to alleviate the broader suffering the loss exemplifies, because the broader aim outlasts the eventual achievement, or impossibility, of the narrower one. Time since the catalyzing event is relevant in a non-linear way. Purposes formed in the immediate aftermath of trauma show higher rates of dissolution as the acute distress recedes. Purposes that consolidate in the medium term, between six months and two years after the event, and persist beyond that show durability. Social support specifically for the purpose is relevant. Survivors whose communities recognize and sustain the aim show higher rates of durable commitment than those in communities describing the aim as evidence of unfinished grief.

Purposes formed in response to adversity are at elevated risk of converting into the constraint pattern as the original catalyzing context recedes. The cause that organized the bereaved survivor's life through the acute and intermediate phases of grief can become, a decade later, what forecloses the post-grief life the survivor needs to build. The transition from source to constraint is often invisible to the person undergoing it. An empirical opportunity exists to study this transition with longitudinal designs that track source pattern purposes from formation through the years that follow, watching for the constraints the next section describes.

Open questions for the source pattern

Are there adversity features (specific traumas, specific developmental phases at onset) that produce reliably durable source pattern purposes? Is the source pattern purpose's characteristic vulnerability, namely overcommitment to the catalyzing event, modifiable by intervention?

Purpose as Constraint

Purpose has been described as a kind of psychological medicine, powerful enough to add years to a life, halve the risk of dementia, recruit the immune system, and protect against depression and suicidal thinking. The problem with the metaphor is that the same commitment that delivers the protective effects has costs. A person committed to a life-organizing aim has fewer adaptive options than a non-committed person in the same circumstances because the alternatives have been actively foreclosed by the commitment that holds the aim in place.

The constraint pattern is what we are naming the dark side of meaningful work. The argument of this section is that the dark side of meaningful work, the trap of caring for a loved one, and the burden of the bound life are not separate phenomena requiring separate explanations. They are configurations of the same purpose reviewed in the buffer section, operating on inputs that, in a non-purposeful person, would simply be situations to manage. The constraint pattern does not require the purpose to be misguided or the situation to be unusual. It requires only that a person holds a purpose and that difficulties press against it.

How purpose narrows options

Laboratory studies of goal commitment show what is happening at the level of attention. When a person commits to a goal, the mind starts to suppress alternative goals, and the suppression is strongest precisely when those alternatives would serve aims comparable to the chosen one (Shah et al., 2002). The committed person is not weighing options and rejecting them. The options simply do not show up as possibilities in the first place. When the commitment is not a single goal but a purpose that organizes whole domains of a life, the effect is wider because the purpose governs many goals at once rather than one behavior, and the effect is deeper because abandoning a purpose feels like losing a piece of oneself.

When a commitment begins to fail, the person enters what researchers call an action crisis, a period when the costs and benefits of the commitment become compulsively accessible after months of being effectively pushed aside (Veronika Brandstätter & Schüler, 2013). The action crisis is itself stressful. Marathoners showing action crisis profiles produce elevated cortisol responses on race day and underperform their pre-crisis baselines (V. Brandstätter et al., 2013). The same machinery that allowed the person to bear the maintenance period is what fails them when it is time to leave. A clinical lineage parallel to the experimental work has named the same phenomenon under the rubric of values-rigid versus values-flexible commitment, with rigidity emerging as a clinical phenotype distinct from commitment intensity (Hayes et al., 2019).

Three illustrative variants

Calling and entrapment. Deeply meaningful work binds the worker to the occupation in ways that produce persistent self-sacrifice of pay, personal time, comfort, and relational availability (Bunderson & Thompson, 2009). The case of zookeepers shows both sides of the experience. Workers reported the work as ennobling and a source of moral duty, and they reported it as exacting costs that comparable workers in non-calling occupations would ignore. The double-edged sword is inherent to adopting the feature of meaningful work referred to as a calling (e.g.,(Duffy & Dik, 2013). The pattern generalizes beyond zoos. Consider the academic professor with a research program that pays poorly, or the clinician whose compassion is dedicated to patients makes burnout an indictment of self along with the role itself. When the self is wed to

a calling, standard career advice must be supplemented (*Dik, B. J., & Duffy, R. D. (2015). Strategies for Discerning and Living a Calling. In P. J. Hartung, M. L. Savickas, & W. B. Walsh (Eds.), APA Handbook of Career Intervention, Vol. 2. Applications (Pp. 305–317). American Psychological Association.*, n.d.).

Caregiver entrenchment. Long-duration informal caregiving provides an empirical demonstration of constraint as a health phenomenon. Strained spousal caregivers in the Caregiver Health Effects Study showed mortality risks 63% higher than demographically matched non-caregivers across four years of follow-up (Schulz & Beach, 1999). A meta-analysis of 23 studies confirmed the pattern across stress hormones, antibody profiles, and self-reported health (Vitaliano et al., 2003). The literature treats caregiving as generating two classes of strain. Primary stressors are anchored in the care role itself. Secondary intrapsychic strains involve the diminishment of self-concepts (Pearlin et al., 1990). The intrapsychic strain is the constraint in action. The caregiver's purpose has not weakened. It has consumed parts of the self, leaving the person with fewer footholds for the post-caregiving life that the eventual death or institutionalization of the charge will require. Patient perspective evidence reinforces the point. A large international qualitative survey of informal caregivers prioritized functioning and well-being outcomes, which are the parts of life the constraint had foreclosed, over symptom relief in the patient (Chevance et al., 2020).

Activism under sustained suppression. Social justice and human rights activists exhibit a constraint pattern with its own moral coloring. A grounded theory analysis of activists across United States movements documented a culture of martyrdom organizing the social environment in ways that made disengagement read as betrayal, with the result that activists pushed past sustainable limits and burned out at rates that reduced movement effectiveness (Chen & Gorski, 2015). The constraining condition, namely suppression of the cause and harm to the people the activist is trying to protect, cannot be exited without abandoning the purpose. The purpose has been bound to identity tightly enough that abandonment looks worse than the costs of staying. When the bond between self and group reaches a particular density, supplemented by sacred value endorsement, a person's willingness to absorb extreme cost, including death, increases reliably across cultures and movements (*Gómez, Á., Martínez, M., Martel, F. A., López-Rodríguez, L., Vázquez, A., Chinchilla, J., Paredes, B., Hettiarachchi, M., Hamid, N., & Swann, W. B. J. (2021). Why True Believers Make the Ultimate Sacrifice: Sacred Values, Moral Convictions, or Identity Fusion?. Frontiers in Psychology, 12, 779120.*, n.d.; Whitehouse, 2018); this might be referred to as identity fusion.

Pathology after the constraining condition lifts

The constraint pattern has a distinct pathology that emerges after the constraining condition has lifted. Consider the caregiver whose charge has died, or the activist whose movement has won or dissolved. The constraining condition is gone, but the cognitive narrowing that resulted from it persists. Field standard outcome measures rarely detect the resulting impaired state. A systematic review documented that 95% of depression treatment trials measured neither healthy functioning nor purpose as outcomes (Rottenberg et al., 2018), a parallel review reached similar conclusions for the anxiety literature (McKnight et al., 2016), and the argument that functional impairment belongs in mental health outcome research has existed for nearly two decades (McKnight & Kashdan, 2009b).

Across a ten-year longitudinal cohort, only about ten percent of adults with major depression reached a strict profile of elevated positive functioning a decade later (Rottenberg et al., 2019; Rottenberg & Kashdan, 2022). None of forty-two cases of generalized anxiety disorder reached the same threshold at ten-year follow-up (Disabato et al., 2021). Roughly one in seven young people who survive a suicide attempt reach elevated positive functioning at seven-year follow-up, com-

pared with about one in four nonclinical peers (Tong et al., 2022). The diagnostic threshold for depression is no longer met but the cognitive narrowing that organized around the pathological state has not yet been unbuilt, and well-being is what is missing. Different evidence emerges from the study of acute life disruption. About 13% percent of the Virginia Tech campus community reported reduced anxiety, and 7% reduced depression, in the year following the campus shootings (Mancini et al., 2016). The interruption made previously inhibited alternatives briefly visible. A related finding appears in military samples, where time elapsed since a suicidal ideation episode predicts the recovery of meaning and purpose (Bryan et al., 2021).

The construct of derailment is the perceived sense that the self has changed in ways that the person did not author and does not endorse (Burrow et al., 2020). The construct has been validated across adulthood and behaves as a distinct risk factor from depression or anxiety (Ratner et al., 2022). Identity disruption of this kind shows up starkly in populations where the constraining condition has been removed but there has yet to be a new set of strivings or personal projects to replace it. Nearly half of returning combat veterans facing difficulty reintegrating back into civilian life describe identity disruption in free response, and the disruption predicts PTSD severity, lower life satisfaction, and impaired social support recovery (Mitchell et al., 2020). Derailment is the *experiential* face of the constraint that lingers after release, and its measurement gives the framework an empirical handle on a state the symptom-based outcome literature fails to detect.

Implications for intervention

The standard repertoire of advice for adversity in close relationships, dependent care roles, and activist contexts is inadequate when the adversity is inside the purpose filter. Instructions like leave the abuser, set better boundaries, take a sabbatical, and delegate the caregiving ask the person to make a choice the constraint pattern has rendered unavailable. The intervention question is no longer what the person should do. It is what would have to be true for the person to perceive the option at all.

The most direct answer the field has produced is self-affirmation. The focal commitment loses primacy in the self-concept under affirmation, allowing other parts of the identity to become accessible long enough to support adaptive thoughts (Cohen & Sherman, 2014). A recent meta-analysis of 129 self-affirmation studies (combined $N = 17{,}748$) confirmed the effect's robustness, with delayed effects on psychological barriers exceeding immediate ones, and with the effect on self-perception reliably stronger in adults than in adolescents, that is, in the population for whom the maintenance phase of a life-organizing purpose is already in place (Zhang et al., 2025). Affirming a part of the identity that is not the purpose can restore psychological flexibility, and the more expansive view of available selves is what makes alternative choices, often referred to as pathways (Snyder et al., 2000), recognizable again.

The regulatory flexibility framework specifies the mechanism through which the affirmation effect operates (Bonanno et al., 2023, 2024; Bonanno & Burton, 2013). The constraint pattern is regulatory flexibility constricted around a single aim. The constraint is visible in all three components of the framework. Context sensitivity is reduced because the relevant context is read through the lens of the bound commitment. The repertoire of strategies available shrinks because each strategy is evaluated for whether it serves the aim rather than whether it helps improve the outcome in a given situation (Kashdan & Rottenberg, 2010). Feedback responsiveness fails because several potential choices of what to do are prematurely ruled out as irrelevant to the person's purpose.

The emotion regulation literature maps usefully onto this logic. Emotions can be deployed instrumentally, strategically increased or decreased to serve goals that promote a sense of meaning

or joy (Weidman & Kross, 2021). Across six studies and 1,409 participants, people recruited emotions as tools in daily life, and when negative emotions were harnessed in this way, outcomes were better than when the same negative emotions arose reactively. The prediction for the constraint pattern follows directly. A person whose purpose has reduced their emotional repertoire can recover access to emotions that the purpose has been underweighting, such as anger to mobilize an exit, fear to signal a threshold, or sadness to permit grief over a foreclosed life (Kashdan, Disabato, Goodman, Doorley, & McKnight, 2020). These emotions can be deployed deliberately rather than waiting for them to arise. The same logic underlies the broader framework of emotion goals that consider effort a central variable in regulation (Hu et al., 2025; *Mauss, I. B., & Tamir, M. (2014). Emotion Goals: How Their Content, Structure, and Operation Shape Emotion Regulation. In Handbook of Emotion Regulation (Pp. 361–375). Guilford Press.*, n.d.; Tamir, 2021). Beliefs about emotion modulate the effect, with people who believe emotions are controllable showing better psychological outcomes (Ford et al., 2018; Ford & Gross, 2019). Combinations of strategies matter more for outcome than any single strategy (Ford et al., 2019; Kashdan et al., 2020). A constraint pattern intervention might address these simultaneously, because each helps improve well-being and healthy functioning.

Goal adjustment capacity offers a further intervention target. The capacity to disengage from unattainable goals and reengage with alternative ones predicts well-being across the lifespan (Wrosch et al., 2003).

Open questions for the constraint pattern

Does the willingness to exit an unhelpful goal follow a cost-benefit calculus? The framework predicts that exit becomes possible when the part of the self that is not bound to the purpose has accumulated enough independent content to outlast its loss.

Can the emotion-as-tool literature offer insight into reducing constraint problems? The prediction is that purposeful people lose instrumental access to emotions that would signal cost, such as anger, fear, and sadness, and that retraining people on how those emotions can be useful widens the range of available options without requiring the purpose to be relinquished.

Can self-affirmation improve purposes and their consequences? Standard affirmation asks the person to write about what matters most. For a person whose purpose is fully integrated, what matters most is the purpose, and the affirmation reinforces identity ties. The prediction is that the constraint pattern requires affirmation of self-content that lies outside the purpose specifically.

Purpose as Target

When purpose is the target, the adversity is aimed at the purpose itself. The dissident is imprisoned because of the dissidence. The whistleblower is retaliated against because they questioned the machine and did something in hopes of improving it. The convert is shamed because of the conversion. The activist is ostracized because of attempts to create a more ideal world. What distinguishes the target pattern from the other three is the adversity's intentionality. A person or institution recognizes the purpose as the source of behavior the institution wants to suppress, and acts to dismantle the purpose by raising the cost of pursuing it.

The empirical literature on the target pattern is fragmented across fields. The whistleblower retaliation literature documents the costs imposed on individuals who report wrongdoing inside organizations. In a survey of 9,900 employees on a US Air Force base, the strongest single predictor of retaliation was the whistleblower's perceived lack of support from others, with gendered differences in the pathways through which retaliation arose (Rehg et al., 2008). The whistleblower case is the target pattern in canonical form. The purpose (to improve society by addressing wrongdoing) is the behavior the institution wants extinguished, and the institutional

response is calibrated to make further pursuit of the purpose costly enough that the person who holds the purpose disengages.

What the evidence shows about durability

The most striking feature of the target pattern evidence is the duration of purpose under sustained assault. Historical and contemporary cases show people who maintain commitment across years of imprisonment, exile, threats to family, financial ruin, and physical risk. The biographical literature on twentieth-century political resistance, that is, figures who maintained organizing aims through extended persecution, is the standard data source, supplemented in recent decades by interview-based studies of survivors of authoritarian regimes who reconstructed their purposes after release (*Hewstone, M., & Martin, R. (2010). Minority Influence and Innovation: Antecedents, Processes and Consequences. Hove, UK: Psychology Press.*, n.d.; *Jetten, J., & Hornsey, M. J. (2010). Rebels in Groups: Dissent, Deviance, Difference, and Defiance. John Wiley & Sons.*, n.d.)(e.g.,).

The durability is not unconditional. Several predictors of purpose maintenance under the target pattern have emerged across the literatures. *Shared purpose community* is the strongest predictor as people who maintain access to other people that recognize and sustain the aim show higher rates of durable commitment than people who are isolated (which might be geographic or ideological). The community sustains an aim the person can no longer publicly enact. *Symbolic representation of the aim in available materials* matters. People who have access to texts, songs, or practices that encode the purpose can rehearse it internally even under conditions that prevent public expression. *Age at onset of the assault* matters (Brewin et al., 2000; Croft et al., 2019)(e.g.,). Purposes that have consolidated for at least several years before the assault begins show higher durability than purposes that are still in formation, with the developmental literature suggesting that this difference is mediated by the depth of identity integration the purpose has achieved.

The literature on purpose extinction under the target pattern is smaller and more painful. Sustained isolation, the absence of symbolic supports, and active counter-conditioning together increase the extinction of the aim in a subset of those targeted. The phenomenon is not the same as strategic disengagement. The person does not exit the purpose tactically and recover it later. The trauma literature has documented the analogue at the level of basic functioning, but the version specific to purpose has not been studied with the precision required.

The relationship between the target pattern and the other three

A single life can pass through all four types. The bereaved survivor whose purpose is to advocate for others facing similar problems enters the source pattern at the catalyzing loss, operates in the buffer pattern through the maintenance period as the purpose softens the chronic strain of advocacy, enters the constraint pattern as the maintenance period extends past the original grief, and enters the target pattern if the advocacy aim attracts opposition that calibrates costs to dismantle it.

The empirical separability of the types is a lingering measurement problem. The whistleblower retaliation evidence treats outcomes (career loss, mental health) as if they reflected the buffering effect of purpose, when the data also encode the costs that exist after foreclosure of the prior career trajectory characteristic of the constraint pattern. A study that pools these types of adversity will overestimate buffering and underestimate cost.

When opposition alters purpose

When the institutional opposition is itself the kind of thing the purpose is aimed at, the assault might feed the purpose. The civil rights organizer whose purpose is to oppose a specific regime gains motivational fuel from the regime's persecution. The persecution offers evidence that the purpose was correct. The framework predicts that this feedback loop converts the target

pattern into a hybrid source-and-target pattern, where the same event functions simultaneously as catalyst and assault. The hybrid pattern can produce extraordinary durability, with the purpose reinforced by every act of persecution. It can also produce extraordinary extinction, with the loop failing and the purpose dissipating faster than ordinary target pattern adversity would predict. Future research can identify the predictors of which trajectory emerges.

Open questions for the target pattern

Is purpose extinction under sustained assault distinct from the literature on trauma sequelae? The prediction is that extinction is distinct, with its own time course, its own resistance to standard trauma interventions, and its own recovery trajectory after the assault ends.

Is standard advice given to those whose purpose is targeted (security training, self-care, community building) operating on the right variables, or has the literature been treating downstream symptoms? This is an actionable question for clinical and policy research.

Extensions to Thinking About Purpose

The adversity evidence reviewed above requires extensions to how purpose is conceptualized. The extensions specify what earlier purpose theories left implicit because the questions the four types inspire did not arise in the original evidence base.

Phase sensitivity

Adversity evidence requires consideration of how the four types operate. The source pattern is probably most accessible during formation. The buffer pattern is the steady state response of purposes in maintenance. The constraint pattern becomes detectable as maintenance extends. The target pattern can occur in any phase. Without explicit phase tracking, the existing literature has been pooling phase-distinct phenomena and producing estimates that average over heterogeneous processes.

Type sensitivity

The four types describe the situation the purpose is in, not the kind of person who holds it. This distinction might be important for intervention design. A caregiver whose purpose is buffering them and a caregiver whose purpose has become a constraint can appear similar on outcomes but require different interventions. Distinguishing them will reduce mismatched suggestions and individual non-response rates.

Updated mechanisms

Prior conceptual models of purpose located the locus of maintenance in the self (Damon, 2025) (Kashdan et al., 2024). The adversity evidence shows that community partly buffers, partly enables (in the constraint pattern, by validating the bound aim), partly catalyzes (in the source pattern, by recognizing the survivor's emerging purpose), and partly sustains (in the target pattern, where it is the strongest predictor of durability). The community's role is part of how purpose operates, and its presence or absence is a parameter that should have been borrowed from long-standing work showing that human development unfolds through a nested set of cultural, social, economic, and political influences (U. Bronfenbrenner & Ceci, 1994; Urie Bronfenbrenner, 1977)(e.g.,). The extension is the recognition that self-organization, on the relevant timescales, occurs in a social field, and the field's properties affect the ways that individual-level accounts of purpose operate.

Interventions

The intervention literature has been almost entirely focused on the buffer type (Park et al., 2019; Schulenberg et al., 2008)(e.g.,). The agenda includes developing specific interventions for each of the other three. Interventions for the source pattern help people whose purpose has formed in response to a specific catastrophe to broaden the aim before the original cause runs its course. A parent who lost a child to a particular cancer and now organizes their life around

research on that cancer may, in year two, find the aim narrowing around fundraising for one research lab. The intervention is to help the parent articulate the broader purpose the loss exemplifies, such as easing the suffering of families facing pediatric illness, so the aim survives when the specific lab closes or the specific research line is abandoned. A useful exercise asks the person to list multiple expressions of the same underlying purpose that do not depend on the catalyzing event, and to try one of them in upcoming months.

Interventions for the constraint pattern help people recover access to parts of the self that the purpose has been overshadowing. A spousal caregiver who has spent years devoting daily activity around a partner with dementia may have lost contact with the friendships, hobbies, and professional identity that existed before the diagnosis. The intervention is to help the caregiver re-engage one element from outside the caregiving role each week, not to replace the purpose but to thicken the surrounding self enough that exit, when it eventually comes through death or institutionalization, does not feel like annihilation. Self-affirmation exercises directed at content outside the purpose, psychological flexibility training, and explicit work on the instrumental use of emotions like anger and grief are candidate components.

Interventions for the target pattern help people whose purpose is being deliberately dismantled by others to sustain commitment under assault. A whistleblower facing professional retaliation, or a dissident under surveillance, loses the public expression of the purpose first. The intervention is to provide private rehearsal of the aim through trusted communities, texts, or practices that encode the purpose, so that the aim can be maintained internally. Helping the person identify even one other person who recognizes the purpose, and arranging regular contact, is protective.

The above are starting points rather than tested protocols. Each is consistent with the mechanisms reviewed earlier, and each is testable.

Pursuing Comprehensive Purpose Science

The science pointed toward with this purpose framework is one in which the four types of adversity are routinely measured and explored as mechanisms that influence the benefits and costs of purpose, and the interventions that improve downstream healthy outcomes. Existing science on purpose tends to pool purpose-adversity interactions into a single construct. Our suggestion is to refine how the adversity side of purpose science is contemplated and calculated when modeling human activity.

The goal is to go beyond simplistic notions of how purpose can benefit a person during difficult times. What our framework offers is a way of thinking about purpose under adversity that the field has been operating without, and a research agenda that will lead to continual advancements in understanding the trajectory of emotional disturbances and positive mental health.

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